

Week 3: Early Settlements in Nigeria

JSS1 Nigerian History — First Term Lesson Note (Deep-Dive Edition)

Introduction

Long before Nigeria became a modern nation, advanced societies flourished within its present-day borders. This week examines four of the most significant early settlements known through archaeology: Nok, Igbo-Ukwu, Ife, and Benin.

Nok Culture

The **Nok culture** flourished in central Nigeria (the Jos Plateau area) from around 500 BCE to 200 CE. First discovered in 1928 near the village of Nok, this culture is known for its distinctive **terracotta (clay) figurines** of human and animal forms, and for practising early **iron-smelting** — among the earliest known in sub-Saharan Africa.

Igbo-Ukwu

Igbo-Ukwu, in present-day Anambra State, is famous for elaborate **bronze artifacts** dated to around the 9th century CE, discovered accidentally in 1938 by a farmer digging a well. The bronzes — including ceremonial vessels, ornaments, and regalia — reveal a wealthy, highly skilled society with advanced metalworking techniques, among the earliest bronze-casting traditions known in West Africa.

Ife

Ile-Ife, in present-day Osun State, is regarded by the Yoruba as their spiritual and ancestral homeland. Between roughly the 12th and 15th centuries, Ife artisans produced remarkably naturalistic **terracotta and bronze heads** using the lost-wax casting method, considered among the finest achievements of early African art. Ife's traditional ruler, the **Oni**, remains a senior traditional monarch among the Yoruba today.

Benin

The **Kingdom of Benin**, in present-day Edo State, rose to prominence under its Eweka dynasty, believed to have begun around the 13th century. Benin is world-famous for its skilled brass and bronze casters, who produced elaborate **plaques and sculptures** for the royal palace, depicting kings (**Obas**), warriors, and court life. Benin City grew into a large, well-organized capital with walls and a moat protecting the royal palace.

Comparing the Four Settlements

Settlement	Known For	Approximate Period
Nok	Terracotta figurines; early iron-smelting	c. 500 BCE – 200 CE
Igbo-Ukwu	Elaborate bronze ceremonial artifacts	c. 9th century CE
Ife	Naturalistic bronze and terracotta heads	c. 12th–15th century CE
Benin	Bronze/brass plaques; walled royal capital	c. 13th century CE onward

Real-Life Application

The bronze and terracotta works of Nok, Igbo-Ukwu, Ife, and Benin are displayed today in museums across Nigeria and the world, standing as evidence that sophisticated, organized societies existed in Nigeria many centuries before European contact.

Vocabulary

Word	Meaning
Terracotta	Hard, reddish-brown clay used to make pottery and figurines
Bronze/Brass casting	A metalworking technique for shaping molten metal into sculptures
Regalia	Ceremonial objects or decorations symbolizing a ruler's authority

Evaluation Questions

- 1 Where was the Nok culture located, and what is it best known for?
- 2 When were the Igbo-Ukwu bronzes discovered, and roughly how old are they?
- 3 What are Ife's bronze and terracotta heads known for artistically?
- 4 What title is given to Ife's traditional ruler?
- 5 Which dynasty is associated with the rise of the Benin Kingdom?
- 6 Describe one feature of Benin City's royal palace or capital.
- 7 Compare the approximate ages of Nok and Igbo-Ukwu — which is older?
- 8 Why is early iron-smelting at Nok considered historically significant?
- 9 Explain what lost-wax casting achieves in bronze artwork.
- 10 In your own words, explain why these four settlements are important to Nigerian history.